NASA's Swift Telescope Falls to Earth After 22 Years

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One of NASA's most famous space telescopes has come down to Earth. The Swift **Observatory** plunged back into the atmosphere on Wednesday, ending a 22-year mission studying the universe's biggest explosions. The U.S. Space Force confirmed that Swift re-entered near Indonesia after tracking its sinking orbit. Intense **solar activity** over the past few years had dragged the telescope lower and lower. NASA had tried to save it. The space agency hired a private company, Katalyst Space, to rush together a **rescue mission** that would boost Swift's orbit. But the company's three-armed robotic craft ran into trouble after its July launch and came crashing down in September. It is not yet known how much of the nearly one-and-a-half-**tonne** spacecraft burned up in the atmosphere. NASA expects that some of the denser pieces survived the fall. Swift launched in 2004 on what was meant to be a two-year study of **gamma-ray bursts** and exploding stars. Instead, it kept working for 11 times longer than planned, observing thousands of these cosmic blasts and acting as a first responder for other telescopes, which could then look more closely. One famous catch was the **afterglow** of a giant gamma-ray burst called GRB 221009A. Now NASA is looking at how to protect another famous telescope: Hubble. Launched in 1990, Hubble is expected to come down by the mid-2030s, according to recent analyses. The agency is asking private companies for ideas about boosting Hubble's orbit, upgrading its systems, or guiding it to a controlled re-entry, and any mission would need to happen by 2032. "Hubble still has important science ahead of it," NASA Administrator Jared Isaacman said in a statement. "And we should be looking at every reasonable opportunity to keep it delivering for as long as possible."

Word Treasure

gamma-ray bursts -- Gamma-ray bursts are huge, brief explosions in space that give off powerful light.

Observatory -- An observatory is a place or machine built to watch space.

afterglow -- An afterglow is the light left behind after a bright flash.

tonne -- A tonne is a unit of weight, about the same as 1,000 kilograms.

solar activity -- Solar activity means changes and storms on the Sun.

rescue mission -- A rescue mission is a plan to save something in danger.

Background you need

A space telescope is a telescope that orbits Earth and looks at the universe from above the atmosphere.

Gamma-ray bursts are huge, brief explosions in space that give off powerful light.

The Sun goes through active periods that can heat Earth's upper air, which can drag low satellites down.

A rescue mission in space means sending a craft to fix or move another spacecraft.

Break it down

LEAD: NASA's Swift telescope falls to Earth after 22 years
KEY EVENT: Re-entry near Indonesia after the orbit sank
+- WHO: NASA, the U.S. Space Force and Katalyst Space
+- WHEN: Wednesday, after 22 years in orbit
+- WHY: Intense solar activity dragged the telescope down
EVIDENCE: Launched in 2004 for two years, it worked for 22 and watched thousands of gamma-ray bursts
OPEN QUESTION: Can Hubble be saved before it falls?

Why it matters

Space telescopes help us see the universe, and losing one shows why scientists work to protect the ones we still have.

Test what you remember

1. Where did Swift re-enter Earth's atmosphere?

- (A) Near Australia
- (B) Near Indonesia
- (C) Near Canada
- (D) Near Brazil

2. How long did Swift work in space?

- (A) 2 years
- (B) 30 years
- (C) 22 years
- (D) 11 years

3. What was Swift built to study?

- (A) The surface of the Moon
- (B) The weather on Mars
- (C) Gamma-ray bursts and exploding stars
- (D) The rings of Saturn

4. Why did Swift's orbit sink?

- (A) A broken solar panel
- (B) A software mistake
- (C) A crash with another satellite
- (D) Intense solar activity

5. What happened to the rescue craft?

- (A) It ran into trouble and crashed in September
- (B) It is still in orbit today
- (C) It successfully lifted Swift's orbit
- (D) It never launched

6. By when could Hubble fall to Earth?

- (A) By the mid-2030s
- (B) By 2040
- (C) By the end of 2026
- (D) By 2032

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: B 2: C 3: C 4: D 5: A 6: A

Questions to think about

1. NASA Administrator Jared Isaacman: says Hubble still has important science ahead of it and every reasonable opportunity should be taken to keep it delivering

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):